

Fight To The FINISH

A slugfest between the former Advocate General and retired Lokayukta creates a stink in Madhya Pradesh

| By Ambreesh Mishra |

The judiciary in India has not been without its share of scandals but the one rocking Madhya Pradesh promises to rank prominently in the gallery of shame. Last week, the scandal was exposed in public when two legal luminaries of the state left office in a blaze of controversy. The first was the outgoing Lokayukta, Justice Ripusudan Dayal, whose six-year term ended on June 22, the day the state's Advocate General (AG) R.N. Singh, resigned from his post, alleging harassment by the anti-corruption ombudsman. The dramatic turn of events dates back to March 3 when a social activist filed a complaint against the AG with the Special Police Establishment (SPE) of the Lokayukta. The voluminous complaint carried a litany of allegations against Singh, his wife Sushila Singh, who is the mayor of Jabalpur, and his son, Mrigendra Singh, a practising lawyer at the Jabalpur High Court. The fact that there is bad blood between Singh and Dayal has only added spice to the affair.

The complainant, Manoj Tripathi, has alleged that Singh had bought a dried-up pond as land in Barha village of Jabalpur and prevented the locals from using it whereas it was clearly shown as a pond in the easement documents of the Revenue Department. Besides, the complainant had also levelled allegations against Singh regarding construction of a palatial school in the village, encroachment

on a Muslim graveyard, renovation of his properties to the tune of Rs 2 crore and purchase of a property in an upscale locality of Bhopal, Riviera Township. The allegations against the Singhs are serious. His wife Sushila, as mayor of Jabalpur, is alleged to have awarded the contract for computerisation of Jabalpur Municipal Corporation (JMC) records to the blacklisted Indore-based firm, Elbiz Systems. The complainant also alleged that payments were made to the vendor without any work being carried out. Likewise, it was alleged that the flat of Singh's neighbour G.C. Stewart at Ashiana Enclave in Jabalpur was auctioned on the pretext of non-payment of water dues and bought by their son, Mrigendra, whereas relatives of functionaries of such bodies are barred from participating in such auctions.

Singh refutes these allegations. He says that the pond was duly bought with a full payment of Rs 7.50 lakh. As for the renovation of his Jabalpur home, it was done before assuming office as AG and the purchase of property worth Rs 25.62 lakh in Bhopal was made possible by a loan of Rs 20 lakh from Punjab National Bank. "The details of my properties are consistent with my income tax returns. As for the allegations against my wife, she would respond if she deems fit," he says. His sudden resignation has raised additional questions with Singh alleging that Justice Dayal had acted against him out of ill-will. "The Lokayukta entertained a complaint not filed in proper format. Besides,

ANIL TOWARI



Charges against Singh

Former Madhya Pradesh Advocate General

- Buying a dried-up pond as land in Barha village of Jabalpur.
- Building a palatial school and encroachment on a village graveyard.
- Renovation of his properties to the tune of Rs 2 crore.
- Purchase of a property in an upscale Bhopal locality.
- Wife Sushila Singh, as Mayor of Jabalpur, allegedly gave the contract for computerisation of Jabalpur Municipal Corporation records to a blacklisted firm.